

Joe Andaloro

Professor Frechette

MSC3999 Capstone Journal

29 April 2026

Weeks 4-5 — 2/1-14: Preproduction

During this time, I began to finalize my sixteen scholarly sources, organizing them into an abbreviated literature review. Reading through these papers, I have made many discoveries about the academic examination of memes in marketing, as I had not realized how thoroughly the phenomenon had been studied in recent years. This allowed me to focus on my thesis on the gap between ingenuine imitation and authentic participation that brands sometimes struggle with when dealing with meme marketing, which I have labeled as the ‘authenticity gap.’

Furthermore, my Capstone has grown from purely focusing on successful and unsuccessful attempts at meme marketing to also including successful and unsuccessful *unintentional* attempts at meme marketing, with the latter dealing with brands’ marketing being made into memes online, both for better and for worse in the eyes of the brands. These types of case studies in particular are unique, as the brands’ lack of intent to utilize internet humor when marketing inevitably results in the audience’s organic hijacking of brand assets and the brands’ following lack of control. The brands’ reaction then determines whether it is positive through adaptability or negative through criticism in the eyes of the audience.

Additionally, while my original intention was to identify, document, and examine five case studies over the course of my Capstone project, my expansion into unintentional meme marketing has allowed me to find more case studies, where I have found examples for each

category: two for successful meme marketing, two for unsuccessful meme marketing, two for successful unintentional meme marketing, and two for unsuccessful unintentional meme marketing, totaling eight case studies that will be examined in my Capstone project. All of these case studies will accurately and fully investigate how meme marketing is influenced by communication, media, psychological, and social theories, allowing for a thorough and comprehensive investigation into the subject matter.

Weeks 6-7 — 2/15-28: Drafting & Outlining

For these weeks, I have begun to outline my project completely, filling in information based on all of my case studies, claims, and connecting them to overarching theories that support whether the eight instances of meme marketing were successful or unsuccessful. My outline and the first draft of my script follow the sequence of an introduction to meme marketing and my thesis, two main parts of case studies, and a conclusion with my findings, lessons learned, and final takeaways.

The first half of part one of my project is then in the structure of an introduction to both successful and unsuccessful meme marketing, an introduction to specifically successful meme marketing, a case study on Wendy's 2018 "#NationalRoastDay" Tweets, a case study on Dr Pepper's 2026 "Dr Pepper Baby" jingle, and a conclusion to successful meme marketing. The second half of part one then consists of an introduction to unsuccessful meme marketing, a case study on DiGiorno's 2014 "WhyIStayed" Tweet, a case study on SunnyD's 2019 "I can't do this anymore" Tweet, a conclusion to unsuccessful meme marketing, and a final conclusion to both successful and unsuccessful meme marketing.

Next, the first half of part two then consists of an introduction to both successful and unsuccessful unintentional meme marketing, an introduction to successful meme marketing, a case study on McDonald's 2023 "Grimace Shake" online trend, a case study on the 2022 movie Minions: The Rise of Gru with its trend of "Gentleminions," and a conclusion to successful meme marketing. Finally, the second half of part two involves an introduction to unsuccessful unintentional meme marketing, a case study on Pepsi's 2017 "Live for Now" commercial, a case study on Grubhub's 2020 "Delivery Dance" commercial, and a conclusion to unsuccessful unintentional meme marketing. As previously stated, the body portion of my case studies will be book-ended by an introduction and conclusion, setting up the framework in the beginning and establishing essential findings at the end.

Weeks 8-9 — 3/1-14: Rough Production

While working on my Capstone during this time, I have started polishing my script as well as recording scratch voiceovers for each section. Each of my case studies follows the formula of examining the background of the meme and its marketing, the audience's response, the company's response to the audience, and applicable theories to each case study. Additionally, each case study would also have coordinating pictures, links, and overall assets. By recording scratch vocals and editing together a rough cut, I am able to see where unnecessary bloating is in my project, cutting out pointless and redundant information while also making the video as focused as possible.

My literature review and bibliography have also expanded beyond its original sixteen scholarly sources, with my gathering of assets, clips, screenshots, links, and news articles growing to over twenty entries. As I continue to revise my outline and script, I plan to have well

over thirty entries in my final Capstone project, with the original sixteen scholarly sources for a theoretical and psychological framework, links to each branded social media post, links to audience posts in response to the brands' posts, cultural context during the time of posts, public apologies by brands for unsuccessful meme marketing, and engagement analytics for successful meme marketing.

Altogether, I plan on my script ending up about twenty pages long and my final video being around twelve to fifteen minutes in length. My video will feature myself as a sort of "self-interview," acting as a talking head speaking to the camera in between graphics, screenshots, clips, and other visual assets. This framework will be effective in its presentation due to my active engagement with the audience, providing sources and visuals when possible without merely spewing off information without foundational facts, research, or connecting greater theories to each case study and claim.

Weeks 10-11 — 3/15-28: Finalizing Artifacts

During the past few weeks, I have made both significant changes to and progress on my capstone project. Most importantly, I have cut down the number of case studies that I will be examining from eight to four. While their inclusion would provide a fuller image of meme marketing, they were cut due to length, required too much background context, and used unnecessary theories unapplicable to my thesis. The four case studies that I have cut were the 2026 "Dr Pepper Baby" jingle by Dr Pepper, the 2022 "Gentleminions" trend for Universal Pictures' Minions: The Rise of Gru, SunnyD's 2019 "I can't do this anymore" tweet, and Grubhub's 2020 "Delivery Dance" commercial.

Additionally, I have tentatively finished my bibliography. With the removal of sources pertaining to my cut content, I have a total of 36 sources at the time of writing. In the future, I may add more sources of visuals to compliment my video and will update my bibliography if necessary. Likewise, I have restructured my capstone to reflect this change of content, as well as to better indicate the difference between successful and failed cases of meme marketing, with the two halves being Part 1 and Part 2, respectively. The structure is now the following:

- Introduction
- Part 1: Successful Meme Marketing
 - o Intro: Successful Meme Marketing
 - o Case Study 1: Wendy's – “#NationalRoastDay” (2018)
 - o Transition: Successful Unintentional Meme Marketing
 - o Case Study 2: McDonald's – "Grimace Shake" (2023)
 - o Outro: Successful Meme Marketing
- Part 2: Failed Meme Marketing
 - o Intro: Failed Meme Marketing
 - o Case Study 3: DiGiorno – “#WhyIStayed” (2014)
 - o Transition: Failed Unintentional Meme Marketing
 - o Case Study 4: Pepsi & Kendall Jenner – “Live for Now” (2017)
 - o Outro: Failed Meme Marketing
- Conclusion

Through this structure, I have finished my script, clocking in at 40 pages including headers and citations. Without headers and citations, the word count is 5251 words, or equal to around 25+ pages if presented as a traditional paper. In total, this would make my project around

20-25 minutes long, which I hoped to avoid due to the immense processing power on my computer and the time needed to record and edit the video. I will still record and begin editing, but if the project seems too enormous, I may request to submit a regular research paper in lieu of an analytical video, in addition to its original script, bibliography, and production journal. This may also allow me to add my cut case studies back into my project with the necessary details to support them, but I will reach out if I begin to believe that this method is a better course of action.

Week 12 — 3/29-4/4: Production

This past week, I have begun production on my analytical video. I recorded for around two hours, taking my time to get good takes of my reading the script. Not only did I record my audio, but also video, sitting in front of a green screen while speaking to the camera. While the total recording time was very long, I have pieced together the first initial edit of the video, landing around 40 minutes. This is much longer than I hoped for, but I recognized that I may be in over my head with the video essay method a few weeks ago.

Throughout the editing process, I have been removing the green screen behind myself in each shot. This has proved to be entirely more difficult than I expected, making for a hard time getting clean-looking shots of myself. Nonetheless, I persisted through my goals to the reluctance of my computer, which was working very slowly the entire time due to the large amounts of footage and editing work.

In hopes of giving my laptop some rest from intensive editing work, I pivoted and started to make a PowerPoint presentation for complimentary visuals. I filled the slideshow with all of my sources, allowing for a clean transition between video sections and its case studies.

Altogether, I must admit that I am beginning to rethink my initial goal of making an analytical video essay due to the immense computing work that must be done. Truthfully, I don't think that my laptop can handle a video as long as it's shaping out to be, I think I may have to reconsider my end goal, instead turning my video script into a research paper.

Week 13 — 4/5-11: Pivoting to Research Paper

I have decided to fully change my approach to my capstone project, now converting my script to a research paper. As my original intention of producing a video took quite a toll on my older laptop due to its sheer volume of images, videos, and audio clips, I now see that my video idea is just not feasible. Instead, I have turned its script into a completed research paper, totaling around 50 pages. With a bibliography at its end with around 50 sources, the paper is rather expansive, covering my four aforementioned case studies with supporting visuals and rigorous investigative analysis.

In addition to the research paper and its bibliography, I also have this production journal to submit if necessary, chronicling my experience with the capstone project over the past ten weeks. At this point, I have been re-editing my research paper every few days, re-reading it with a fresh set of eyes to find places in the text where I can improve my wording, reasoning, or supporting details. I am very proud of the state of my paper at the moment and believe that it is worth replacing the video project that I originally set out to accomplish. I have recently learned that I will be presenting my capstone via Zoom on Wednesday, April 29th, with class taking place from 6-9pm and my presentation being 3rd in line. Until then, I will be constantly revising and improving my paper, but I believe that the majority of my work has now been thoroughly completed.